



CODE SPORT

In this month's column, let's take a break from technical topics and instead have a humorous shot at, "What does it take to succeed in a software career?"

For the last couple of months, we have been discussing dynamic languages such as JavaScript, and how they differ from traditional statically compiled languages like C or C++. I have received a few emails from our readers in response to these columns. As you know, CodeSport has tended to mainly focus on C or C++ over the last few years. Hence, there have been questions from our readers as to why this column's focus has shifted to Web languages, and whether I see it as more of an industry trend—with the usual question on whether C or C++ is dying.

These emails made me take a second look at some of the common questions most software developers face, as we meander through our careers. While my first thought was to do a serious discussion of this topic, my common sense asserted itself in time, and I thought that since there are so many self-help books for software developers that presumably do that, let us take a lighter look at this question, in this month's column.

So, what does it take to succeed as a software developer?

Well, I obviously don't claim to know the entire answer to that question, so I invite our readers to send in their thoughts on this subject. Drop me a mail at sandyaasm@yahoo.com, with the subject line 'Success recipes for a software developer'. I

plan to summarise the inputs and share them with *LFY* readers in next month's column.

Software development as a career is complex, and does not have an established recipe for success. This is, of course, true for most complex human development activities, whether it is in the field of arts or sciences. However, let us try to explore some practices that can help you along the path to success.

Missing Manual Notes for Software Developers (MMNSD)

There are certain truths that no college curriculum for software programmers spells out. We call these the 'Missing Manual Notes for Software Developers'.

Note 0: The only thing you can be certain will not change is change itself.

While this is true for life in general, it is more glaringly evident in a software developer's career. If you start by learning Language 'X' as the universal language that guarantees you success as a software developer—well, by the time you finish mastering X, the world has gone on to 'Y' and so on, ad infinitum. All of us have been bitten by this one. For instance, I started learning JavaScript a few months back. By the time I could reasonably grapple with prototypical inheritance, function objects and closures, the JavaScript world has gone ahead to 'Node.js', server-side JavaScript and CoffeeScript.